

Vincent finds the key to future greatness

With his title win at the Chennai Grand Masters 2025, at the same venue where Carlsen assumed his throne over a decade ago, Keymer has lined up the pieces for a parallel that **may not be too hard to trace.**

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German Grandmaster Vincent Keymer remembers following the 2013 World Chess Championship final as an eight-year-old. In that landmark clash, Magnus Carlsen dethroned reigning champion Viswanathan Anand to claim his first world title. "It really stuck with me as a memory," Keymer recalls.

Nearly 12 years later, Keymer found himself at the very site of Carlsen's coronation, competing at the Chennai Grand Masters 2025.

"I've been to India a few times. What's special this time is that we are playing in the same hotel [Hyatt Regency] where Vishy and Magnus played," says the 20-year-old, who stormed through the event to win by two points — a surprising margin in a Super GM tournament.

Keymer, who entered the tournament as the third seed, led from start to finish, subduing his opponents with relentless attacking play. He finished his campaign unbeaten, winning five of his nine games.

Dutch GM Anish Giri, joint second in Chennai, felt that freestyle chess has unlocked a more potent version of Keymer, who started the year with a remarkable win at the Weissenhaus Freestyle Grand Slam, where he toppled some of the world's best, including Carlsen.

"Freestyle will probably be remembered as the thing that turned Vincent into a monster. Because I feel he has realised that he was always very reliant on openings.

"So, in freestyle, he must have discovered that even without openings, he's very good. He now plays very differently and is no longer predictable. He won a lot of games with Black

here," said Giri. Keymer's Chennai exploits earned him over 20 rating points, taking him into the world's top 10 (live rating) for the first time in his young career.

While he cruised to what he considers as his biggest win in a classical event, the Indian contingent mostly struggled to cope.

Top seed Arjun Erigaisi fell away after a strong start, hampered partly by an illness midway through the tournament. Nihal Sarin and Vidit Gujrathi showed glimpses of brilliance but lacked consistency.

Karthikeyan Murali, however, provided a silver lining. Drafted in as a last-minute replacement, the 26-year-old battled hard to finish joint second — with only Keymer managing to beat him.

"I think Karthikeyan was excellent. He showed a lot of ambition despite being thrust into the Masters section at the last minute. It was a very noteworthy performance," said Indian GM Srinath Narayanan, the tournament director.

For Srinath, Karthikeyan's performance underlined the central objective of the event.

"The fabric of the tournament is to provide an opportunity for those who wouldn't otherwise get it, and to be a stepping stone to much higher



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